INDIA or the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, the broader Opposition bloc. Calling the alliance with AAP a "mistake", he said it had tarnished the Grand Old Party's credibility. This public denunciation, along with the decision to release a white paper detailing AAP's administrative failures, signal a big shift in the party's strategy—a pivot away from depending on coalitions to rebuilding its own electoral machinery. Two weeks later, Maken's offensive received public endorsement from the Congress high command, with leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi holding Kejriwal responsible for the "rising corruption and pollution" in Delhi, and even drawing a parallel between the AAP leader and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, accusing both of making false promises.

The Congress decision comes at a crucial juncture. The 2024 Lok Sabha election results were a mixed bag. While the Modi-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won a historic third consecutive term in power, the Congress-led INDIA bloc found a glimmer of hope in the saffron party's failure to secure a standalone majority. That optimism proved shortlived as INDIA faced crushing losses in Haryana and Maharashtra—two critical states the bloc had pinned its hopes on. These setbacks not only blunted the significance of the bloc's victories in Jammu and Kashmir and Jharkhand but also derailed the momentum and sparked cracks within the coalition. Discontent simmered among the allies, with many openly questioning the Congress and Rahul Gandhi's ability to spearhead the challenge against the BJP juggernaut. West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) has been looking to position herself as a contender to lead the coalition. Her push for leadership has found backing from Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) or NCP (SP) leader Sharad Pawar and Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) supremo Lalu Prasad Yadav.

Mamata's push for the leadership of the INDIA bloc has found backing from allies like Sharad Pawar, Lalu Prasad, which has irked the Congress

The Congress's mixed fortunes in



ALL AT SEA INDIA bloc leaders watch as Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge addresses the press, June 1, 2024